

MGT 402 – Data Driven Communications

Winter 2026

Class Meetings:

Tuesdays — January 6, 13, 20, 27; February 3

11:00 AM – 1:50 PM

Location: 3E 107

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Office Hours: Tuesdays, 2:00 – 3:30 PM, and by appointment

DESCRIPTION

In today's lightning-fast global business environment, the ability to communicate persuasively and to explain data effectively both in person and virtually is essential. This highly participatory course equips analytical professionals to translate complex technical information and business insights into clear, compelling messages for diverse audiences.

You will learn techniques for high-impact presentations, including eye contact, vocal presence, effective gestures, and clear, visually engaging slide design. You will also develop the transformational skills that distinguish exceptional communicators: speaking directly from the mind and heart to influence the hearts and minds of others. Through practice, you'll experience the power of authentic, data-driven storytelling and build confidence in tailoring your message to different audiences.

Drawing on approaches from communication, theater, and leadership training, the course helps you connect with audiences in ways that are both memorable and motivating. A combination of lecture, demonstration, creative exercises, improvisation, peer feedback, and individual coaching will guide you in refining your data-driven communication for a range of business contexts.

Each session includes the development, rehearsal, and delivery of key messages using proven templates and coaching methods. You will leave the course more confident, creative, and compelling—ready to lead through communication that earns attention and inspires action.

OBJECTIVES

- Greater comfort and confidence presenting across multiple platforms
- Techniques to draw in, engage, and move audiences to action

- Confidence in being spontaneous and “in the moment,” and adapting to audiences with diverse backgrounds
- Experience using your authentic interests, passions, and real-life experiences as the foundation for effective communication
- Practice in essential skills including eye contact, gestures, vocal projection, and use of imagery
- Knowledge of templates, techniques, and structures for more succinct and articulate presentations
- Strategies for creating effective visual materials
- A working vocabulary for observing, analyzing, and discussing the presentations of others

READING MATERIALS

Books available via the UCSD Library

To access the UCSD library (<https://library.ucsd.edu>) from off campus you must first connect to VPN. How to set up: <https://library.ucsd.edu/computig-ad-technology/connect-from-off-campus/index.html>

1. *Storytelling with Data*, by Cole Nussbaumer Knafllic
Available online via UCSD Library:
https://search-library.ucsd.edu/permalink/01UCS_SDI/1vtf07t/cdi_askewsholts_vlebooks_9781119621584
2. *Slide-ology: The Art and Science of Creating Great Presentations*, by Nancy Duarte
Available online via UCSD Library:
https://search-library.ucsd.edu/permalink/01UCS_SDI/1vtf07t/cdi_proquest_miscellaneous_743450273

Articles:

1. “The Science Behind Storytelling”
2. “Get the Boss to Buy In: How to sell Your Ideas Up the Chain of Command” by Susan J. Ashford and James Detert
3. “Structure Your Presentation Like a Story” by Nancy Duarte

SCHEDULE, ASSIGNMENTS AND READINGS

Date	Due	Class Topic & Activities	Assignments
Week 1	On Canvas Pre-Class Questionnaire: About You	Winning the First 60 Seconds In theatre, actors’ auditions are	Prepare opening 2-3 minute Presentation #2 for Week 3

	Reading Storytelling with Data Introduction p. 1-17 Chapter 1 – The Importance of Context p. 19-33 Article: The Science Behind Storytelling <u>In Class</u> you will begin to develop opening for Presentation #2 Starting a key data- driven presentation to create relationship, interest and establish credibility.	won or lost in the first 60 seconds. Management presentations are often the same! Your audience makes decisions about You, your Content, Data, Message, and Competence the MOMENT you begin. Your confidence, tone of voice, choice of words, body language and gestures all convey key information and propel audiences to engage or not. In this session, you will develop and rehearse the opening of an upcoming presentation. We will explore opening structures and techniques to invite your audience to connect with your material and you. Standing Ovation presentations begin by Winning the First 60 Seconds.	
Week 2	Reading Storytelling with Data Chapter 7 – Lessons in Storytelling p165-186 Chapter 2 – Choosing an Effective Visual p35-60 Article: “Structure Your Presentation Like a Story” – by Nancy Duarte In Class you will develop and deliver Presentation #1 – an authentic story from 4 options	Authenticity, Improvisation and Storytelling Great speakers feel spontaneous and authentic shaping their communications “in the moment” to audiences. Presenters must effectively improvise when they: field questions, converse with panels, adjust to unexpected circumstances, and reshape and rework material for specific audiences. When networking, you must listen, think on your feet, ask questions, express what you are doing, and connect. You will learn basic techniques in theatre improvisation and then practice opportunities to use these skills to plunge “off the page” in management presentations and conversations.	Prepare opening 2-3 minutes Presentation #2 for Week 3
Week 3	Presentation #2 Starting a key data- driven presentation to create relationship, interest and establish credibility. Reading Slide-ology	Data Storytelling You now have access to more data than ever, but how will you communicate it clearly, persuasively, and with impact to diverse stakeholders? Your data can lead to invaluable recommendations if you can shape it into an effective “data story.” In this class, you will learn and	

	p. 2-7 Creating a New Slide Ideology p. 14-16 Responding to Audience Needs p. 19 Case Study: Rick Justice p. 88-107 Arranging Elements p. 212-213 Template Guidelines p. 222-223, 230-231 Interacting with Slides p. 248-249 A Call to Relate	practice techniques for getting individuals, teams, boards, and organizations to genuinely “buy in” to the compelling story your data reveals.	
Week 4	Reading Storytelling with Data Chapter 3 - Clutter is your enemy p. 71-98 Chapter 4 - Focus Your Audience’s Attention p. 99-126 Chapter 5 – Think Like a Designer p. 127-150 In class, you will develop and deliver Team Presentation #1- Persuading an audience to take a desired action.	Graphic Design & Structure Leadership presentations paint vivid pictures of a desired future. When Dr. Martin Luther King Jr. declared, “I have a dream...,” he didn’t simply describe the evils of racism, he offered a powerful vision of what could be. How do you create impact when your visuals are limited to a crowded bar chart or text-heavy slide? The most memorable and engaging moments often come from imagery and metaphor. In this session, you’ll learn to design clear, captivating, and emotionally resonant visuals both in language and slides that animate your ideas, build empathy, and inspire the outcomes you want to achieve.	Presentation #3 4–5-minute-high impact upcoming data-driven presentation including: objective, strong opening, defined relationship, compelling data storytelling, visual imagery and slides.
Week 5	Presentation #3 4–5-minute-high impact upcoming data-driven presentation including: objective, strong opening, defined relationship, compelling data storytelling, visual imagery and slides. Reading Article: “Get the Boss to Buy In: How to sell Your Ideas Up the Chain of Command” by Susan J. Ashford and James Detert	Final Presentations and Intensive Coaching “Previewing” the skills and techniques we have worked on. Each student will give a 4–5-minute data-drive presentation with coaching and critique from instructor and classmates.	

ASSIGNMENTS & DELIVERABLES

Presentation #1 - Will be a story that you plan and deliver entirely in class.

Presentation #2 - Starting a key data-driven presentation to create relationship, interest and establish credibility. Due in third session.

Presentation #3 - 4–5-minute-high impact upcoming data-driven presentation including: objective, strong opening, defined relationship, compelling data storytelling, visual imagery and slides.

All class assignments are C - Collaboration with classmates is allowed. However, each student must present individual work.

Reading Assignments

Are specified in the schedule.

Team Projects

Team Presentation #1 will be developed entirely in-class during 4th session. Topic chosen by team from 3 options given by professor.

Quizzes/Exams

There are no quizzes or exams, but there are two two-minute presentations, a team presentation, and there will be one 4–5-minute final presentation.

Class Participation

It is essential for each student to use each class as an opportunity to actively develop and rehearse presentations and communications. Participants will be expected to give coaching and feedback to classmates. There will be exercises and presentations in every class.

GRADING

Exams and Deliverables	Points [or percentage]
Presentation #1	15%
Team Presentation #1	15%
Presentation #2	20%
Class Involvement	20%
Presentation #3	30%
Total	100%

COURSE POLICIES

Attendance and active participation are essential. You must attend all sessions to receive a top grade. Students are expected to be offer supportive observations and suggestions, be open, authentic, and willing to take risks.

ACADEMIC INTEGRITY

Integrity of scholarship is essential for an academic community. As members of the Rady School, we pledge ourselves to uphold the highest ethical standards. The University expects that both faculty and students will honor this principle and in so doing protect the validity of University intellectual work. For students, this means that all academic work will be done by the individual to whom it is assigned, without unauthorized aid of any kind.

The complete UCSD Policy on Integrity of Scholarship can be viewed at:
<http://senate.ucsd.edu/Operating-Procedures/Senate-Manual/Appendices/2>

STUDENTS WITH DISABILITIES

A student who has a disability or special need and requires an accommodation in order to have equal access to the classroom must register with the Office for Students with Disabilities (OSD). The OSD will determine what accommodations may be made and provide the necessary documentation to present to the faculty member.

The student must present the OSD letter of certification and OSD accommodation recommendation to the appropriate faculty member in order to initiate the request for accommodation in classes, examinations, or other academic program activities. **No accommodations can be implemented retroactively.**

Please visit the [OSD website](#) for further information or contact the Office for Students with Disabilities at (858) 534-4382 or osd@ucsd.edu.